Jammu area and communal harmony was maintained. In fact, it is a matter of great pride for the Kashmiris that even during the partition of India in 1947, there were no communal riots.

During the Jammu tenure, the results of our promotion board were announced, and I stood approved for the rank of colonel. Normally, I should have been promoted in the same branch as my immediate superior, the colonel administration, was due for a posting. However, that was not to be and once again regimental interest prevailed. The Army HQ asked each infantry regiment to absorb two vacancies of colonel's rank in the appointment of commanding officers. My colonel of the regiment decided that I should take over 5 Maratha LI, which happened to be in Hyderabad. Consequently, I was posted as the CO of the 'Fifth Royal', a 185-year-old battalion, which was raised on 21 December 1800. As mentioned earlier, 1/67 Punjab (in which my grandfather served) and 5 Maratha LI had fought together in 1914–15 at Kut-el-Amara during the First World War. For me to command the same battalion was therefore a matter of great pride. I would be with my 'ganpats' once again. Regimental soldiering is the bedrock of leadership in the army and this experience further cemented my belief that command of troops cannot be substituted by any other form of leadership training.

During my command of almost two years, the battalion did well in training, sports and administration. For the first time in its history, the entire battalion was airlifted to an airfield secured by a para assault. This was when we participated in Exercise 'Trishakti', a joint army, navy and air force exercise conducted in Goa. Before this exercise, I was asked to make a presentation to the officers of the division on the subject of an air assault division. I was allowed to go to the Army HQ to search for reference material for this presentation. When I was given this task, the brigade commander's first question was, 'JJ, when can I see the rehearsal?' My response was, 'Sir, if you have confidence in me, then you don't need to see any rehearsals.'